period since Op-1 was launched was intentionally relegated to a non-issue.

The passage of time has not diminished the need to chart a way forward. If anything, the years gone by have shown how the aftershocks of cataclysmic events can last for decades. Indeed, forces inimical to the interests of India continue to find new and creative ways to invoke these very events to their advantage. In the overall interest of the nation, these issues need to be addressed seriously and cannot simply be brushed under the carpet.

Before suggesting a way forward, I would like to examine what had been said or done in this connection by the political parties in or out of power at the Centre since 1984, and how forces arraigned against India's interests are taking advantage of these unresolved issues.

The Congress response, over time

Of the Congress governments that came to power since 1984, nothing was expected from Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi (November 1984 to November 1989) since he was a part of the problem. P.V. Narsimha Rao, who did not succumb to the various pressures of 10 Janpath throughout his tenure (June 1991 to May 1996) as prime minister, could have done something. But his own hands were not clean. Dr Manmohan Singh's minority Congress party-led UPA (United Progressive Alliance) government had no time – or more appropriately, no intention – during its two successive five-year terms (May 2004 to May 2014).

Dr Singh, however, did tender an apology in parliament on 12 August 2005 about what happened in November 1984. But it was more in the nature of a technical apology, meant to cleanse the Congress of its subconscious guilt. That would be evident from the wording of the apology: 'I have no hesitation in apologizing to the Sikh community. I apologize not only to the Sikh community, but to the whole Indian nation because what took place in 1984 is the negation of nationhood enshrined in our Constitution.' [1] But he did not mention who the persons responsible for that 'negation of nationhood' were. Moreover, any such apology should have come